Game of the Boat



Glückshaus specimen from 1583 preserved in the National Museum of Munich

The game of the Boat is a game of chance with dice of medieval origins, originally spread among innkeepers and - above all - mercenaries, especially between the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries in Germany, where it is known as Glückshaus, which can be translated into "House of happiness".

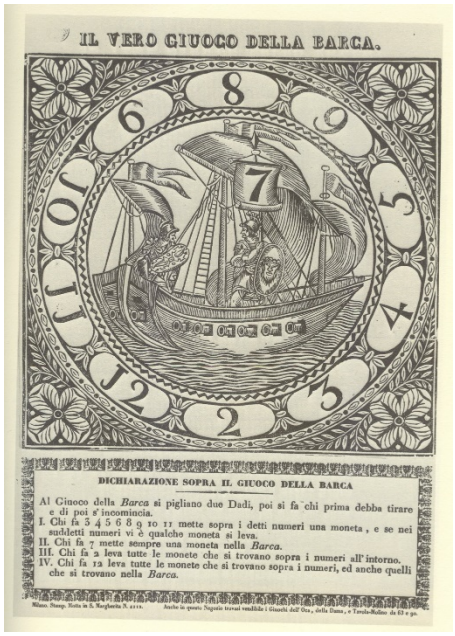
The origin is not certain, but it is certainly one of the many games attributable to the series of games of chance of the "games of seven" series, that is, a series of games in which the number 7 has a central value.

The oldest tables date back to the end of 1400 AD. and are made of wood, with a design more similar to a house with a series of "rooms" adjacent to a central, occupied by 7, with the various numbers except 12 and 2 occupying the outermost "rooms".

On the 2 a boar was often represented, on the 7 instead a pair of rings, referring to a wedding party.

The 12 always represents a crown, symbolizing the king of the game who had this result at the roll of the dice, so much so that in the Italian culture, during the twentieth century, the way of saying do / win "a boat of money" developed in indicate a large amount of money that the roll of 12 allows the king to win.

As a game it was as long-lived as it was opposed in various ways, like all dice games as they almost always involved an economic sphere; for most of the Middle Ages, dice games and gambling in general were considered, both by the Church of Rome and by many states, a trap into which it was easy to fall with the illusion of easy money, ending up mostly for to be prey to cheaters and scoundrels.



Italian print from the 1800s for the Game of the Boat

The German version often lacks the box with the number 4, instead present in the Italian version which replaces the house with the boat, while in Holland the house has become a Harlequin.

As a game it remained in vogue for a few centuries, losing its importance during the nineteenth century. to find a new impetus during the last century, coming back into vogue until the 70s of the 20th century.

PURPOSE OF THE GAME

The aim of the game is to win "a boat of money", that is to collect all the tokens of those present.

GAME'S RULES

This is a game for an unlimited number of players, the number of tokens supplied with the skin is enough for four to have fun.

Starting with an empty board, the players take turns throwing the dice and depending on the result they place or collect the coin.

Basically, if the square is empty a token is placed, if the token is already present it is won by the player.

This does not apply if a 2, 7 or 12 is rolled.

If 2 is rolled, the player wins all the tokens present on the circle, marked by the symbol of the four-petaled flower.

If a 7 is rolled, the player places the token on the boat, even if there are other tokens present.

If 12 is rolled, the player wins all the chips present on the board, both those of the circle and those of the boat.

When a player runs out of tokens, he is out of the game.

GAME'S VARIATIONS

The most well-known game variants concern the number 4.

The original German boards of the glückshaus did not include the "room" with the 4 therefore they opted for one of the following variants:

- The player who rolled 4 passes the turn without doing anything;
- All players pass their tokens to the playmate on their right;
- The player who made 4 pays a token to the owner of the board.

Since the board of the Italian version, reproduced by us, has the box with the 4, it is possible to determine whether to use one of these variants or to treat the 4 as any other box as indicated in the basic rules.



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